

RESERVE NETWORK STUDY

One network across the whole reserve.

We modelled Pumba's terrain from satellite elevation data and checked every radio path against it. two ridge high-sites put 2 of the 2 lodges we could locate on clear radio paths, fed from a carrier uplink on Makhanda high ground.

Prepared for

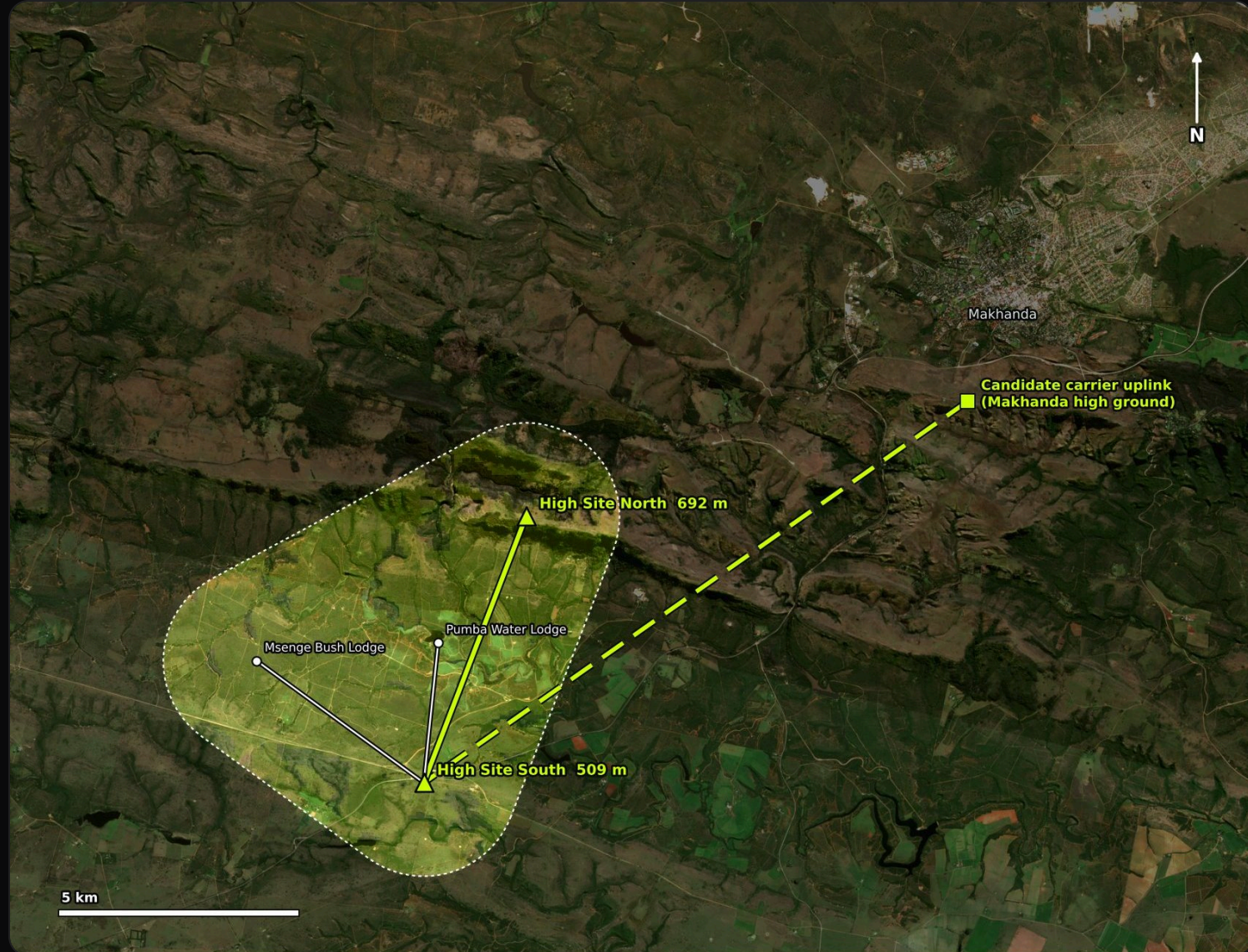
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Date

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--- Carrier uplink
 — Private backbone
 — Lodge link
 Clear line of sight for a 3 m field terminal

Sentinel-2 imagery, 26 March 2026 to 14 July 2026. The dotted outline is the study area around the lodges. Site positions are desktop candidates, to be confirmed on a site visit.

2 of 2

lodges on a clear,
Fresnel-checked radio
path

2 + 0

ridge high-sites plus
short relays

87%

of the 60 km² study
area in line of sight

14.2 km

clear carrier uplink into
the reserve

01 Where things stand today

Pumba runs two lodges, a day-safari arrivals point and a Big 5 security operation on one reserve. The connectivity that is described is lodge Wi-Fi. We propose one backbone that belongs to the reserve and reaches the field.

02

Carrier in, private network out

Carrier connectivity comes into the reserve once. Everything past that point runs on infrastructure the reserve owns.

LAYER 1 · CARRIER

Uplink from Makhandanda high ground

An uncontended business-grade Vodacom service, delivered by CTTX over a 14.2 km link to High Site South. LTE failover keeps the reserve connected if the carrier path drops.

LAYER 2 · BACKBONE

Ridge high-sites

High Site South (509 m) and High Site North (692 m) sit 6.1 km apart with a clear link between them. Each site runs on solar and lithium storage with remote monitoring, so the network stays up through load-shedding.

LAYER 3 · DISTRIBUTION

Every lodge and ops site

Sector radios reach the lodges, HQ, the anti-poaching base, ecology, the workshop and the gates. A LoRaWAN gateway is ready for fence, water-point, pump and fuel sensors.

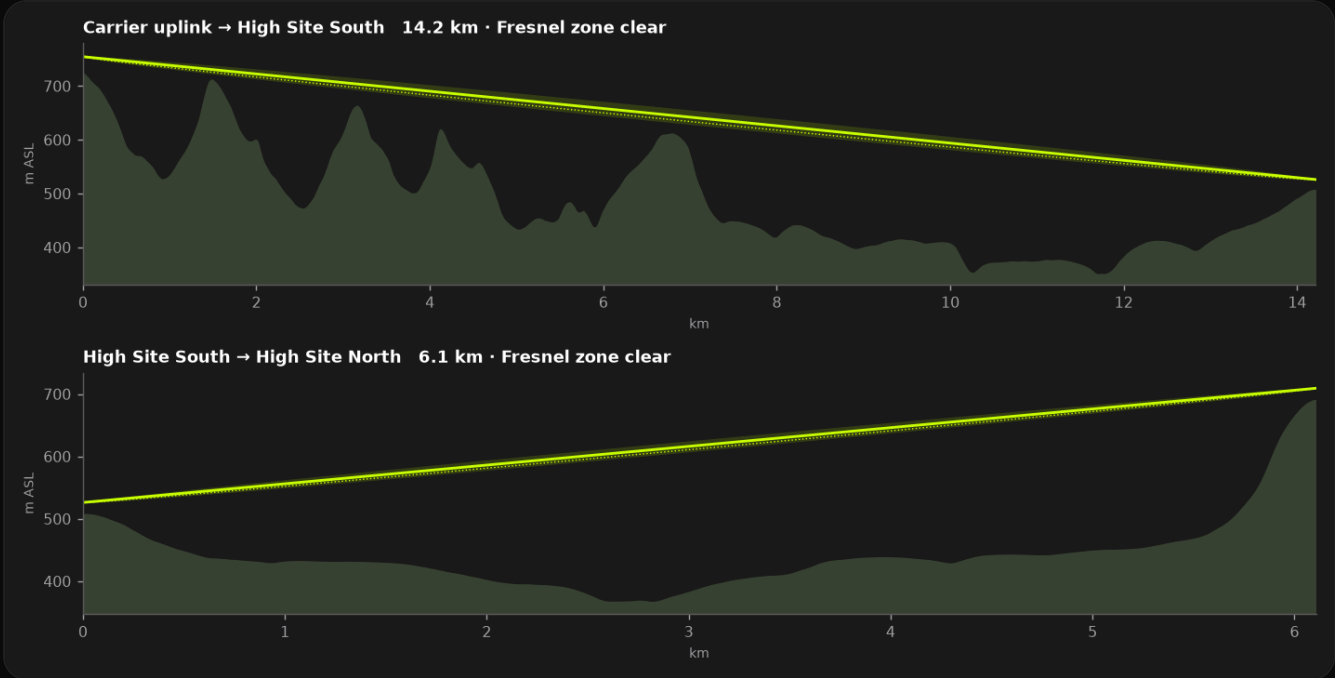
BUILT FOR WHAT COMES NEXT

Once the backbone covers the reserve, a new camera, sensor or lodge is an endpoint on a network that is already there. It is not a new infrastructure project or a new provider contract.

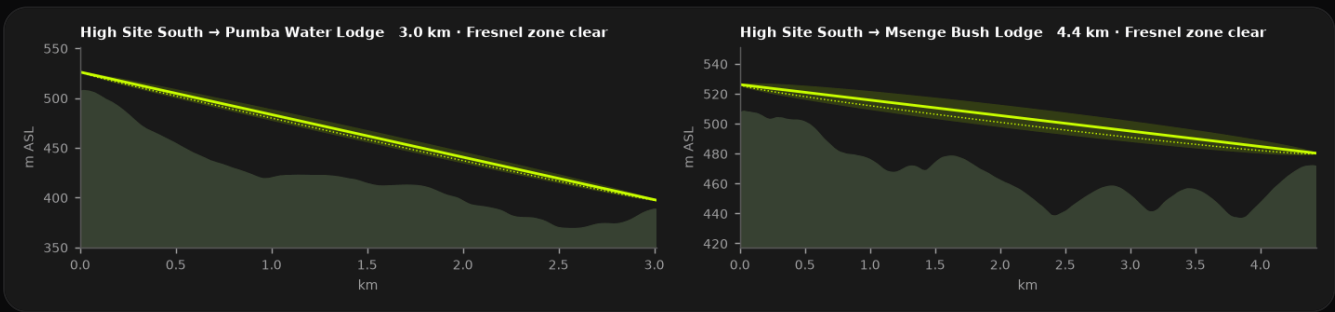
03

Every path checked against the terrain

Each profile shows the ground between two sites, the radio path (lime line) and its Fresnel zone (lime band). We allow for earth curvature and require at least 60% of the zone to be clear at every point. A path that fails is not drawn.



LODGE	SERVED FROM	PATH LENGTH	LINE OF SIGHT
Pumba Water Lodge	High Site South	3.0 km	CLEAR
Msenge Bush Lodge	High Site South	4.4 km	CLEAR



5.8 GHz · $k = 4/3$ · uplink tower 30 m · high-site masts 18 m · lodge masts 8 m. Lodge positions come from published GPS coordinates.

04 One backbone for every driver of the business

A reserve network carries three loads at once. This design is built to hold all three on one backbone.

GUEST EXPERIENCE

Reliable Wi-Fi, booking and card payments at every lodge.

STAFF COMMUNICATION

Lodges, HQ, rangers and maintenance on one network, day and night.

SECURITY AND OPERATIONS

Cameras, gates, fence alarms and sensors on the same backbone, powered through load-shedding.

05

What other properties got back

Sandymount Safaris 30,000+ ha, three lodges

BEFORE

A consumer wireless service at about 3 Mbps down and 8 Mbps up, with the provider on site daily to swap IPs and reinstall equipment.

AFTER

A Vodacom-backed 100 Mbps symmetrical link into the reserve, a CTTX-built main mast and two secondary masts, solar and lithium power, all monitored remotely.

GUEST EXPERIENCE

HD sport streams live at the lodges. Guest connectivity is no longer something the lodges think about.

STAFF COMMUNICATION

Over 800 Mbps measured across the reserve's own backbone, linking the main lodge, Mountain Retreat and Samar.

SECURITY AND OPERATIONS

Daily provider callouts went to zero. Every fault used to need a vehicle and a person; now the network is monitored remotely.

OWNERSHIP

The reserve keeps adding systems on top of the backbone. In the client's words, they stopped doing speed tests.

WHEN THE NETWORK GOES QUIET AFTER HOURS

Elephants broke out after 21:00 and staff had no effective way to coordinate. The requirement that came out of it: dependable communications after hours, across the areas where an incident can happen.

An Eastern Cape lodge near Addo

OWNING THE NETWORK PAYS FOR ITSELF

Replacing a rented, contended service and rented Wi-Fi with a lodge-owned network breaks even in under three years on connectivity savings alone. It also connects areas the old setup never reached, including the spa.

The same lodge, business case from its own invoices (Sep 2026)

06

What it pays back

A reserve that replaces a separate rented connection and rented Wi-Fi at every lodge with one owned backbone typically recovers the investment in under three years on connectivity costs alone. The security, operations and guest-experience benefits come on top of that.

YOUR NUMBER, NOT OURS

Send us each lodge's latest connectivity invoice, or just the monthly totals, and we will work out Pumba's actual payback. It takes us a day.

BUILT TO BE FORWARDED

If infrastructure decisions sit with someone else, please pass this on. Owners will find the payback and ownership case, the reserve manager the security and operations case, and lodge managers the guest experience case.

What changes when the reserve owns it

TODAY

17

WITH A RESERVE BACKBONE

- One uncontended carrier feed shared across the reserve
- Lodges, HQ, the anti-poaching base and gates on one private network
- Coverage out into the field, day and night
- An owned asset that takes cameras and sensors without new towers

Avoided loss

Pumba has spoken publicly about how fast a rhino incident unfolds: about seven minutes from darting to departure. A backbone that reaches the gates, cameras and rangers is what makes a response inside that window possible.

Operational efficiency

Water points, pumps and fuel tanks report their own status, so there are fewer vehicle trips just to check. Maintenance, ecology and lodges share one communications path.

Infrastructure ownership

High sites, backbone and power belong to the reserve. The network grows with the reserve instead of depending on each lodge's separate provider.

Executive risk reduction

Management gets live visibility of the network, cameras and sensors, and a record of operational diligence for owners, insurers and conservation partners.

Next steps

1

30-minute call

Your lodges' current connectivity costs, your peak usage, the incidents that were hardest to coordinate, and what currently needs a vehicle trip to check.

2

Confirm the sites

A marked map of HQ, the anti-poaching base and the gates. We add them to the model and rerun the link plan.

3

One day on the reserve

We walk the high sites and relay points, and confirm the carrier uplink with Vodacom.

4

Design and proposal

A final design in Cambium LINKPlanner, with equipment, power, a phased plan and the investment case.

Method. Terrain: Copernicus DEM GLO-30 (30 m). Imagery: ESA Sentinel-2 L2A true colour, 26 March 2026 to 14 July 2026. Radio model: 5.8 GHz, effective earth radius factor 4/3, 60% first-Fresnel-zone clearance at every point. The terrain model does not include trees or buildings. Every path is confirmed on survey before anything is built.

Candidate positions. High Site North -33.35227, 26.41559; High Site South -33.40357, 26.39170; carrier uplink -33.33052, 26.51728 (Makhanda high ground). The exact carrier site is subject to Vodacom feasibility.

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